

CONTROVERSIAL AND SENSITIVE CURRICULUM STANDARDS

The Loudoun County School Board recognizes that preparation for effective citizenship is one of the major purposes of education. The Virginia Standards of Learning and the LCPS Curriculum include topics that are controversial and/or sensitive.

A. Purpose. To provide guidelines for school-based and non-school-based administrators, teachers, and students in dealing with controversial or sensitive curriculum standards in ways that develop critical thinking skills and reflect sensitivity to the emotions often engendered by such topics.

B. Definitions

1. A controversial topic has significant academic, social, political, and ideological matters about which there exist opposing viewpoints and/or multiple perspectives within the K-12 educational setting.

2. A sensitive topic is a resolved historical fact within the curriculum or one that can lead to a sensitive conversation that must be addressed in a manner that supports a safe learning environment for students.

C. Expectations for Instruction. In teaching controversial and sensitive curriculum, the instructional staff is expected to adhere to the following expectations:

1. Conduct the study of the controversial and sensitive curriculum in an atmosphere in which facts and knowledge related to the curriculum can be freely accessed and the critical thinking of students can be developed through inquiry within the guidelines of the instructional program.

2. Establish a learning environment where each student can study the topics within a curriculum that is appropriate to the student's knowledge and maturity and learn to discuss controversial and/or sensitive topics in a civil manner that promotes intellectual integrity and preserves personal dignity.

3. Take steps to mitigate bias when presenting content on controversial and sensitive content. When there is doubt about the impact of a controversial issue in planned instruction, inform the principal about the topic, relevance to curriculum and the instructional strategies that will be used to mitigate bias.

4. Ensure clarity of the learning objective for teaching curriculum-related controversial and sensitive topics. Consensus should not be an intended outcome when students engage with controversial topics in the curriculum.

5. Remind students that they must adhere to the Student Rights and Responsibilities as well as school and classroom expectations for behavior.

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D. Expectations for Communication with Stakeholders

1. Prior to engaging in a planned lesson on sensitive or controversial topics, teachers must inform families and students of learning goals and the content.
2. Be aware that students might have strong reactions to controversial or sensitive content. Families and school counselors should be informed if reactions interrupt student learning.
3. Prior to inviting guest speakers on controversial or sensitive topics, teachers must have approval from school administration.
4. Be aware that families will be directed and encouraged by the Board and administration to take their questions and comments directly to the teachers concerned as defined in policy 8070.

E. Free from Endorsements. Although the instructional program includes the study of the political party system in the United States, including elections and political current events, the School Board and LCPS employees do not endorse any political party or candidate in a professional capacity.

Adopted: 11/15/22

Legal Ref: Code of Virginia, 1950, as amended, § [22.1-78](#)

Cross Ref: Policy [7524](#), Staff Participation in Political Activities, Policy [7560](#), Professional Conduct, Policy [8705](#), Students Not Required to Convey Certain Materials, Policy [8-65](#), Solicitation, Distribution and Posting, Policy [8070](#) Written Comments and Complaints